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MOMENT OF JOY Mahadevan, Zakir Hussain, V. Selvaganesh and Rajagopalan with the Best Global Music Album Grammy for Shakti's *This Moment* at the awards ceremony in Los Angeles, Feb. 4

"It's

A *TIHAAI*!" QUIPS TABLA MAESTRO Padma Shri Zakir Hussain on being congratulated just a day after the triple whammy at the Grammy Awards. Just a month short of his 73rd birthday, he made history at the ceremony in Los Angeles, becoming the first Indian to win three of these trophies in a single night—in the Best Global Music Performance, Best Contemporary Instrumental Album and Best Global Music Album categories. Hussain now has five of these awards in all, equalling the tallies of the late sitar maestro Ravi Shankar and the master conductor Zubin Mehta; they are all in top spot, incidentally, on the list of Indians with the most Grammy wins.

"It is all about love, all about harmony, all about diverse sounds coming together as one," says Hussain. "The kind of talent that I am honoured to work with is hard to even come by and, here I am, blessed with the privilege of working with them!"

'Pashto', a track Hussain wrote and recorded in collaboration with American banjo player Béla Fleck, American bassist Edgar Meyer and Indian flautist Rakesh Chaurasia, won in the Best Global Music Performance. A tribute to the tradition of Indian classical musicians playing with British imperial bands in early 20th-century India, the song weaves a rich tapestry of rhythm that is signature Zakir Hussain. 'Pashto' features on *As We Speak*—the album which won Hussain (and Fleck, Meyer and Chaurasia) a second Grammy that night, in the Best Contemporary Instrumental Album category. Speaking about the win, and working with Hussain, Chaurasia says, "Zakir Bhai is an institution not just for Indian music, but how he has amalgamated global sounds to make the tabla more recognisable internationally. Like his father, the revered 'Abbaji', Ustad Alla Rakha, who inspired stalwarts of global music, Zakir has changed the way people listen to and appreciate Indian music. The main reason is he believes music is more important than boundaries and boxes."

The third award bagged by the tabla maestro was a validation of this impact. The album, *This Moment*, by fusion band Shakti, featuring renowned artists Shankar Mahadevan, John McLaughlin, Zakir Hussain, V. Selvaganesh and Ganesh Rajagopalan, bagged the Global Music Album category. Fellow band member Shankar Mahadevan says, "I have to credit two giants for letting me take a dip after being in the rollercoaster of my musical journey. John McLaughlin and Zakir Hussain are the pioneers of 'fusion' music. When they started Shakti 40 years ago, they changed the global music scene."

Speaking about this Grammy win, Hussain says, "It is important and significant that Indian music is being appreciated in all its improvised forms. You must understand that this kind of blended music is also very complicated in terms of the amalgamation of varied rhythmic patterns and ragas. And yet people are appreciating it. So this award is for the audience that values it."

Noting the "growing power of Shakti", John McLaughlin says, "When I disbanded the initial Mahavishnu Orchestra, we started Shakti with L. Shankar, Zakir Hussain and Vikku Vinayakram. We disbanded again in 1978 and then reunited with Shankar, U. Srinivas and Vikku's son Selva coming in. Then there was another break and we rejoined in 2020. Last year was the 50th anniversary of Shakti,

THIS MOMENT *IS SHAKTI'S FIRST* NEW STUDIO ALBUM IN OVER 45 YEARS. *LAST YEAR WAS THE 50TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE BAND, WHICH BEGAN WITH A GLOBAL TOUR*